The Big House

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

INTRODUCTION

CLAIRE:	*Elisa, a sweet girl from Utah and a big fan of reality TV, has submitted an audition video for an upcoming reality TV show that I am co-producing. Elisa's tape has passed through to the final round.*
ELISA:	*Today, Claire has invited all the finalists in for an interview. Claire's goal is to determine which applicants are the right fit for the show's premise and will represent the right demographic in the total chemistry of the show.*
CLAIRE:	*When you are a Reality TV Star, you have to be versatile. Will Elisa pass the test? TOGETHER: The Big House by Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota.*

CLAIRE: OK, first things first. *(Putting out her hand.)* Claire Handal! I'm the producer of this new reality show we're developing for CBS.

ELISA: I'm so excited, Ms. Handal!

CLAIRE: Claire, please. I understand. This is very exciting, but this is not the end of the process. You are a finalist, but you're not a house guest. Yet. So where are you from again, Elisa?

ELISA: I live in Ogden, Utah, where nothing ever happens! At least nothing exciting.

CLAIRE: Well, I'm sure that's an exaggeration. I mean, exciting things happen everywhere. So how did you hear about us?

ELISA: Well, my friend Monica Evans from college. We were reading the recap of the rat pit on the Web site of *Fear, Fear, Fear* and we saw the advertisement for house guests and *(Claps her hand.) wham* I sent in a video. And *wham* I'm here. I love all of those shows: *Loser Love Island, Phobia, Stamina, Let's Get Divorced.* They're all so fun!

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CLAIRE: Yes, they are, Elisa. Nothing more fun than watching your fellow man get tortured, taunted, and rejected, is there?

ELISA: Yeah. No. . . I mean, I wouldn't exactly say they're tortured. I mean, you can win a lot of money and there's always a Jacuzzi.

CLAIRE: Yes, that's true. Staying on an island with scantily clad women whose sole purpose is to steal your fiancé, starving in ninety-plus humidity while a bunch of sweaty type-A personalities force you to join their clique, and eating buffalo testicles is fun. Isn't it? Kinda like camp. . . Now, you've read our liability agreement and signed the paperwork?

ELISA: Well, they said I couldn't get through to the interview process if I didn't sign

CLAIRE: Either you're a serious contestant or you're wasting my time.

ELISA: I'm serious as Kelly Clarkson on the first season of *American Idol*. But I do have a tiny question.

CLAIRE: Really? Regarding?

ELISA: Well, about your having no liability for wounds, maims, burns, loss of limb, decapitation, or depression? Well, is that *likely* to happen?

CLAIRE: Is it likely that Michael Jackson will become a Buddhist monk? That Julia Roberts will be happily married? That Dan Rather will correct his lisp? My sense is, no, not likely, but I cannot know in all certainty, can **I,** Elisa?

ELISA: No. Well. . . it might be good if I knew what this one's about? What's the concept? Are we on an island, a beach house, in a studio, what?

CLAIRE: In due time. This will be very different. We don't want just everyone knowing our business. We want this show to stand out from all the rest.

ELISA: That's great! It's going to be different?

CLAIRE: Yes, *very* different. Groundbreaking. Unlike anything that's ever been done.

ELISA: Wow. You mean, the contestants won't meet every week to vote someone off?

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CLAIRE: Well, no, we'll have that.

ELISA: No sexy hot tub scenes, flip-flop alliances and, when the ratings are lagging, some contestant that turns out to be wanted in three states?

CLAIRE: Oh no. We'll have all that. But we won't give out any money.

ELISA: Oh, wow! That *is* different. But why would we do it then?

CLAIRE: *(Patronizing.)* Now, Elisa, is this all about the money for you?

ELISA: *(Pause.)* . . . Yeah. *(Beat.)* Oh. I get it. This is one of those shows where the twist surprise at the end is that you actually do earn the money? Right? But you don't want to tell us.

CLAIRE: Well, if there's a twist, I obviously couldn't tell you!

ELISA: Well, I'd like to be on TV. That guy whose pet ferret went up his pants during his wedding ceremony on *Funny Video* ended up with his very own ferret Web site.

CLAIRE: Sure, there's the fame involved, and then if you were to get invited on the show, you would have the opportunity to live for free, with twelve other adults, in an environment that is cleverly devised by our creative team to be absolutely fun, interesting, and hot-Disneyland for adults. Bunk beds, a bathroom, a basketball court. And you'll get meals too.

ELISA: Oh, nice. Meals? How about a Jacuzzi?

CLAIRE: Of course! That goes without saying. Where will we have the steamy make-out scenes? *(Laughs.)*

ELISA: But I have a fiancé.

CLAIRE: Even better. Is he the jealous type? *(Elisa nods.)* Perfect. But don't worry, you only get to the hot tub if you get off for good behavior and that doesn't seem like you.

ELISA: Good behavior? What does that mean?

CLAIRE: All in good time, Elisa, when I explain the concept. Our goal is to get a very

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broad spectrum of viewpoints, a wide group of very difficult people who can . . . Oh! God. Did I say difficult? I meant diverse people, of course.

ELISA: I'm difficult. I'm very difficult! Diverse, too!

CLAIRE: That's OK, I was in no way saying that you *have* to be difficult-how so?

ELISA: Well. . . well, I . . . I'm whiney.

CLAIRE: *(Unimpressed.)* Yes?

ELISA: And I'm very angry.

CLAIRE: In general or . . . ?

ELISA: Well, I get very angry when people steal my stuff.

CLAIRE: Dh-huh. *(Fishing.)* And when else?

ELISA: No, that's it.

CLAIRE: Elisa. Don't most people get angry when people steal their stuff? What if I were looking for a truly difficult type-the kind who steals away her best friend's boyfriend or bosses around her very old, lame aunt.

ELISA: Well, I did that! I'm difficult! I . . . stole my old aunt's boyfriend!

CLAIRE: You did?!

ELISA: Well, it wasn't exactly stealing. And he wasn't exactly my old aunt's boyfriend. He walked her dog, but she had a little crush on him. And my old aunt's not lame, but she did have kidney stones.

CLAIRE: Oh-kay, Elisa, let's erase all this. We aren't *just* looking for difficult people. We need all types. Just be yourself. We want to capture various types that fit the wide demographics of our audience. That even means some happy, nice people like you. So long as they're between the ages of nineteen and twenty-five and have stellar bodies.

ELISA: I work out daily. I can dye my hair. I have a lot of cut-off tops too. I have a nice flat stomach. You want to see it?

CLAIRE: Not necessary. We collect our essential information *before* you get this far.

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We're professionals here. I just have to tell you that you cannot second-guess what we need here, Elisa. It's all group chemistry. We might need a fat one, we might need an urban type. We might need a very wild and flakey type.

ELISA: *(Raises her hand.)* That's me! Fla-key!

CLAIRE: Dh-huh. I had a feeling. Now, let's discuss some of your fears. Just to keep things interesting. And fun! Look right over my right shoulder and say, "Fears."

ELISA: *(Looks over her right shoulder.)* "Fears." *(She smiles.)* Why did I do that? *(Realizing.)* Oh my God. Is this being taped? *(Fixing her hair.)* Oh gee. Do I look all right?

CLAIRE: Don't worry. We tape all the interviews so we can go back and look through our potentials. Also we use excerpts on the show if anything juicy comes up.

ELISA: Juicy? I've got juicy. Do I have juicy! Midgets!

CLAIRE: What?

ELISA: You know midgets, little people. I'm afraid of them. How's that for a juicy fear?

CLAIRE: *Looks up intrigued.)* Interesting. *(Writes it down.)* Anything else?

ELISA: You didn't like the midget thing?

CLAIRE: O, it was fine, but *Phobia* already did that.

ELISA: They did midget fears?!

CLAIRE: Yep. It blew. People were bored, offended. Got any other fears?

ELISA: Well, sure, I have tons! You name it, I'm afraid of it! Is that what you're looking for, a fearful person?

CLAIRE: Maybe. Is that you?

ELISA: Yes, indeed! I'm afraid of it all. Closed-in spaces, aliens, baby diapers. Big crowds, little rodents, eating flies, flying snakes, ugly dogs, vampires, cable TV, hockey naked!

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CLAIRE: Naked? Did you say you were fearful of hockey naked?

ELISA: Yes! Yes, I am! Is that good?!

CLAIRE: No, but it is weird. Unfortunately, that would get us thrown right off the air.

ELISA: Wait a minute. Are you telling me the sensors will allow tarantula torture cells, snake pits, and eating pig rectums, but somehow naked hockey crosses over the line?

CLAIRE: Unfortunately, Elisa, I'm getting a vibe about all this. I just don't think you're right for our show.

ELISA: What?! Because of the naked hockey?!

CLAIRE: No, no. It's just you seem a little too perky.

ELISA: Perky?! I'm not perky! *(Lowers the Pitch of her voice and affects cool boredom.)* I'm not perky. I was just doin' "perky" because I thought that's what you wanted, man. Actually, I'm very *(Yawns.)* tired and bored. *(She slouches extravagantly.)*

CLAIRE: No, I'm looking for the real you, the you that you are. Just be yourself.

ELISA: *(Calmly.)* OK, OK, I see what you're saying. Here I am. I'm not overly perky. I'm pretty down-to-earth and low-key. I eat a lot of frozen yogurt. I'm really not afraid of anything. I don't have any embarrassing moments or weird old boyfriends.

CLAIRE: No, no, you don't understand, that's worse. I'm not looking for low-key either.

ELISA: Well, what are you looking for then?!

CLAIRE: Prisoners. Look, I'm looking for a group who will fit well into a prison setting. Our show is called *The Big House*. It's a prison environment. But I'm thinking you're too small-town. I'm looking for prison types.

ELISA: Prison? Well, that's great! People from small towns don't go to prison? Have you not heard of white trash, red necks? I've had tattoos. Now granted they

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were cereal box prizes, but I'll go permanent. I'm perfect for a prison. I should have been locked up long ago. *(Swaggers.)* Do you know how many times I've torn the "under penalty of law, do not remove" tag off of pillowcases? Do you know how many times I've made a U-turn over the double yellow lines? Wear my seat belt? Pff. Doesn't happen.

CLAIRE: Yes, but you seem to adapt too easily, Elisa. I mean, I want to put people together in the cells, in the bunk beds, and I don't want adapting happening.

ELISA: I don't adapt *{Yells.}* I don't do bunk beds! What am I nine?! See? I'm rigid.

CLAIRE: Can you give some examples of that?

ELISA: Sure, I'd be happy to. . . *{Realizing. High-pitched.}* No. Hah. No. I can't give examples of that, Claire, or anything else because I don't give answers, you little loser!

CLAIRE: How dare you talk to me like that!

ELISA: Tough! How dare you say I'm adaptable?!

CLAIRE: I'm in charge of this show! *{Stands.}* Do you want me to call security?

ELISA: Call security! Security-Smi-Sma-eerity. *{Confused, trying to make this work.}* Security-Smeerity. Whatever. That's hard to rhyme. My point is that you aren't the only one who gets to ask questions. What fears do you have, huh, huh!?

CLAIRE: I don't really have any big fears.

ELISA: That's a crock! Everybody knows that anyone sick enough to create the *very* different-NOT -*Big House* reality show is full of neurotic tendencies. Vile, disgusting ideas crowd your head. I see it now. Yes, control, entrapment, jealousy, boxed potatoes, and sweaty men playing basketball all summed up by a perky, patronizing host! I don't want to be on your stupid, hot-headed, reality rip-off so you can use me until I'm sucked dry and unable to return to my boring, but pleasant existence. I don't need you, you Hollywood hack, you pursed-

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lipped, tight-buttocks, Prozac-treated ninny! I'm better than you. I'm better than all of you! You can't handle me, Ms. Handal!!

CLAIRE: *{Blown away, pause.}* Wow. You have a lot of nerve.

ELISA: I've never done that before. I, I don't know what. . . came over me.

CLAIRE: I don't know either, but, I'll tell you this, you are absolutely, positively, not getting away from *The Big House.* We start taping next week.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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